
Social Work's Role in Collaborative Community–Academic Partnerships: How Our Past Informs Our Future

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In recent years, community–academic partnerships (CAPs) have gained traction in academia as a method for bridging the research–to–practice gap and reducing health disparities for marginalized populations. The field of social work may be well poised to enhance its ability to engage in partnerships and research around partnerships given its emphasis on conducting practice research and its historical roots in boundary spanning. In this article, the author begins by defining collaborative partnerships between academics and community stakeholders and then states specific advantages and challenges to collaborative partnerships in the field of social work. Throughout, the author explains how the historical foundations of the field (for example, acting as boundary spanners, advocating for marginalized individuals) place social workers in an ideal position to become leaders in the development, sustainment, and strengthening of CAPs. The author details the ways in which social work researchers can use the field's unique history to enhance the development and sustainment of CAPs. The article concludes by encouraging the field to use standardized terminology, methodology, and evaluation procedures when conducting CAPs and providing strategies for social work researchers who wish to increase their ability to develop and sustain CAPs within their own institutions.

KEY WORDS: *collaborative partnerships; community–academic partnerships, community engagement; history; social work*

Historically, research conducted by academics has been carried out in one direction—that is, with academics conceptualizing and implementing research projects with little to no input from community stakeholders (Drahota et al., 2016). Academic researchers working in communities are often distrusted for conducting “hit and run” research, in which they collect data and information from community stakeholders without a plan for sustainability (for example, if the study was an intervention) and without disseminating the results to the community from which the data were gathered (Begun, Berger, Otto-Salaj, & Rose, 2010; Chat-away, 1997). Given that community stakeholders’ firsthand knowledge is hypothesized to increase the relevance of research and feasibility of interventions in the community (Kobeissi, Nakkash, Ghantous, Saad, & Yassin, 2011; Koné et al., 2000), this disconnect and distrust between researchers and community stakeholders has likely contributed to a large research–to–practice gap, whereby research developed by

academics takes an average of 17 years to be implemented into community settings (Balas & Boren, 2000). Issues around voice and trust in research are of special importance to social work academicians, who have historically recognized marginalized stakeholder views and ideas as equally important as those of academics.

Leading scholars have identified partnership between research and community stakeholders as a key mechanism through which to bridge the research–to–practice gap, noting that “the future of the field depends on the ability to utilize partnerships to conduct more rigorous and robust research” (Chambers & Azrin, 2013, p. 509). Certain funding bodies such as the National Institutes of Health (NIH) have emphasized the centrality of research–practice partnerships to eliminating health disparities (Chambers & Azrin, 2013), an indication that funders are increasingly interested in this type of work. NIH (2012) defined and emphasized the importance of research–practice partnerships in a program announcement:

Community-based participatory research (CBPR) is a collaborative approach to research that involves partnerships between communities and researchers to define the research problem, design the study/intervention, analyze the data, and disseminate the results. This approach is particularly well-suited for intervention research with vulnerable populations because it facilitates trust between communities and researchers, promotes the exchange of information and skills, and, most importantly, it can improve the quality, effectiveness, translation, and adoption of interventions aimed at improving the health of vulnerable populations. (p. 2)

Through this definition, one can see that research–practice partnerships have the ability to make research more relevant to the communities that social workers often serve (for example, low-income communities) and to make the implementation of prevention or intervention efforts more feasible for individuals with whom social workers often work (for example, marginalized individuals such as substance users) (Kobeissi et al., 2011; Koné et al., 2000). Research–practice partnerships build social work researchers’ capacity to understand specific contexts through community stakeholder input, thereby allowing researchers to tailor implementation efforts of interventions. Through tailoring, researchers can increase the external validity of evidence-based practices (EBPs), potentially improving the acceptability of such interventions to both practitioners and service users (Glasgow, 2009). Given the increased push in social work to implement EBPs in community settings to bridge the research-to-practice gap, research–practice partnerships provide a helpful paradigm for ensuring that research results are applicable and translatable to community settings (Palinkas, He, Choy-Brown, & Hertel, 2017).

The field of social work is unique in that social work academics are encouraged to conduct practice research (Galinsky, Turnbull, Meglin, & Wilner, 1993). Given that the field of social work has been committed to the empowerment of marginalized and impoverished people from the conception of the profession (Simon, 1994), social work researchers are especially prepared to work in community partnerships in which historically marginalized stakeholders’ views and ideas are recognized as equally important to those of academics. In addition, many

scholars find social work to be at the intersection between a wide array of professions—a field of mediation, where a large portion of social workers’ jobs is to connect services provided by other professions and institutions (Abbott, 1995). As collaborative partnerships require translation of terminology, methodology, mediation, and compromise between stakeholders, social work may benefit a great deal from its unique history as a field of mediation in the development and sustenance of partnerships between stakeholders of varying professions and identities (Jagosh et al., 2012).

Due to the historical role that social work has played in incorporating marginalized individuals’ perspectives into research, and the unique role that social work plays as a mediator between many disciplines, I posit that the field of social work is in an ideal position to enhance its capacity to develop, sustain, and strengthen community–academic partnerships (CAPs).

COLLABORATIVE PARTNERSHIPS

Community-partnered research represents a paradigm shift from the traditional model of research, in which academic researchers conceptualize, develop, and carry out research with little input from community stakeholders (Drahota et al., 2016; Glasgow, Lichtenstein, & Marcus, 2003). Specifically, community-partnered research is driven by the view that the “trickledown model of how to translate research into practice” (Glasgow et al., 2003, p. 1262), characterized by the slow journey from efficacy trials to effectiveness trials to dissemination and implementation research, is flawed and inadequate. The goal of community-partnered research instead includes community stakeholders in the decision-making process from the beginning and aims to conduct research that is not only more valid, but also more relevant to the needs of stakeholders in the settings for which it is ultimately designed (Drahota, Aarons, & Stahmer, 2012; Palinkas et al., 2017).

Throughout the past century, community-partnered research has taken the form of a variety of approaches, including community-based participatory research (CBPR) (Hall, 1992), community-partnered participatory research (Israel et al., 2005), participatory action research (PAR) (Kidd & Kral, 2005), and most recently CAP (Drahota et al., 2016). Although these models have nuanced differences, their unifying theme is the adoption of an equal partnership among researchers and community

stakeholders in the design, development, and execution of research with the shared goal of improving outcomes for members of the community. (For a full review of partnership paradigms used over the last 20 years and their specific definitions, see [Trickett and Espino \[2004\]](#).)

Whereas collaborative partnerships can occur on multiple levels and in multiple contexts, in this article I will refer to them specifically as collaborations between researchers/academic institutions and community stakeholders. The term *community stakeholders* varies by study, topic, and setting, but for the purposes of collaborative partnership research, it will be defined as individuals who have direct decision-making authority or individuals who would be most likely to use or benefit from the evidence generated. Community stakeholders are varied and may include, but are not limited to, practitioners, policymakers, clients, consumers, and community members. Furthermore, community stakeholders may also include organizations, such as local and state governments, tribal entities, grassroots organizations, and advocacy organizations ([Palinkas et al., 2017](#)).

Over the past two decades, scholars have come together to critically assess partnerships and develop what will be referred to as a “science of collaborative partnerships.” Although models such as CBPR and PAR include guiding principles for partnership, they lack a conceptual definition of collaboration ([Drahota et al., 2016](#)). Furthermore, the specific principles included in CBPR (such as including partners from the earliest stages of research) may exclude researchers who do not include collaboration with community stakeholders until later points in their research (for example, when a researcher presents findings to community stakeholders to ask them for their interpretation or specific significance in their context; [Drahota et al., 2016](#)). In addition, researchers whose mission is not social systems change would not fit into the PAR paradigm ([Drahota et al., 2016](#)). Thus, a more inclusive collaborative partnership paradigm is needed. [Drahota and colleagues \(2016\)](#) have developed this model, which they define as follows:

Community-academic partnerships (CAPs) are characterized by equitable control, a cause(s) that is primarily relevant to the community of interest, and specific aims to achieve a goal(s),

and involves community members (representatives or agencies) that have knowledge of the cause, as well as academic researchers. (p. 192)

ADVANTAGES AND CHALLENGES OF COLLABORATIVE PARTNERSHIPS IN SOCIAL WORK

Collaborative partnerships between researchers and community stakeholders offer many advantages and challenges, both of which need to be considered when developing and studying CAPs. Given that social workers have a specific interest in empowering marginalized populations ([Simon, 1994](#)), CAPs should be of interest as they play an important role in facilitating relationships with community stakeholders in an effort to involve individuals who have historically benefited little from participating in research ([Drahota et al., 2016](#)). CAPs present a unique opportunity to work with historically marginalized individuals, or “hard to reach” populations, such as sex workers or men who have sex with men ([Benoit, Jansson, Millar, & Phillips, 2005](#)). Involving marginalized populations in the research process from the start of the project—by having community stakeholders assist with developing the research agenda—helps make research questions more relevant to community needs and increases the potential to design studies that produce usable knowledge relevant to community partners. Involving community stakeholders through the end of the project (for example, having community stakeholders help develop policy recommendations) may make research findings more translatable to other marginalized populations or communities that are often left out of policy conversations ([Benoit et al., 2005](#)). Furthermore, involving community stakeholders in the research process has the ability to increase trust between historically marginalized populations and academics.

Ultimately, the community knows its needs best. When researchers choose to conduct research in communities without involving community stakeholders in the process, they miss an opportunity. Communities are continuously gathering, organizing, and innovating to build safer, healthier, and more vibrant landscapes for their residents. Through partnerships, researchers can preserve indigenous knowledge that already exists and enhance their research by incorporating the voices of community members

who are experts of their own conditions. Training both community members and academicians in CAP methodologies not only works to enhance the local knowledge of the community, but also creates research that is deeply ingrained in the context, in turn improving the sustainability of research in communities beyond the life span of a single grant (Chambers & Azrin, 2013).

Beyond prevention, intervention, action, and implementation research, a wide range of social work research would benefit from CAPs; partnering with community stakeholders has potential to inform a full range of studies, including epidemiological, experimental, and ethnographic studies. *Implementation research*, in particular, defined as “the scientific study of methods to promote the systematic uptake of research findings and other evidence-based practices into routine practice, and, hence, to improve the quality and effectiveness of health services” (Eccles & Mittman, 2006, p. 1), has made great strides at incorporating CAPs into research designs and developing the science of CAPs. For example, implementation researchers have begun the groundwork of identifying implementation strategies that are facilitators to the development and sustainment of CAPs (Pellecchia et al., 2018). Formative evaluation is another important form of community-based research already being used by social workers wherein researchers use “a cyclic process that includes problem framing, planning, acting, observing, and reflecting in order to improve practice” (King, 1998, p. 59). This method of evaluation is aligned with CAPs given its ability to offer opportunities for reciprocal partnerships with communities (Schulz, Israel, & Lantz, 2003). Close ties to the community may help improve relevancy of research, from the questions researchers pose to the development of theory, constructs, and measures, and the interpretation of results. Community-partnered research may not be appropriate or feasible for all studies, but incorporating CAPs in research when relevant and feasible will greatly strengthen the study design and results.

Although there are many advantages to using CAPs in social work, the paradigm is not without flaws. One major challenge to CAP that social workers will likely be especially interested in, given the field’s attention to power dynamics (Sakamoto & Pitner, 2005), is the potential for an unequal distribution of power and perception of power inequalities in

CAPs (Chavez, Duran, Baker, Avila, & Wallerstein, 2008). Although researchers often assume that developing relationships with community stakeholders to share in one or more parts of the research process is sufficient to overcome any power differentials, power inequalities often still exist (Chataway, 1997). The reasoning for this is that academics typically have greater access to resources, expertise on a specific topic, time, and funding than community stakeholders do (Chavez et al., 2008). Chataway (1997) suggested not trying to eradicate the influence of power in CAPs (as it is part of the nature of the context in which you are trying to study), but, rather, try to gain a better understanding of the influence that the existing power dynamics have on the research collaboration, and an understanding of how they may be affecting outcomes.

Another challenge to conducting CAPs in the field of social work is dealing with the conflicting interests and goals of social work academics and community stakeholders. An essential component in any CAP is having a shared goal, vision, or mission for the collaboration and research project (Drahota et al., 2016). However, it has been documented that community stakeholders and academics often have differing motivations for partnerships (Begun et al., 2010). Academics often conduct research with the goals of adding knowledge to the field, publishing in peer-reviewed journals, and receiving grants from high-caliber funding institutions (for example, NIH)—academic incentives, such as promotion and achieving tenure, are often aligned with these goals in mind (Nyden, 2003). Although community stakeholders’ motivations for participating in CAPs vary greatly, a common goal is often improved outcomes (for example, health, social, employment) for members of their community and improved policies. Given the reciprocal goal development that is the nature of CAPs, and the large time investment inherent in community-based work, academics may avoid CAPs as they may inherently cause their research questions to change or reduce their productivity (for example, publishing) rate, which may hinder their ability to receive promotions or tenure within their institution. However, until incentives within academic institutions are adjusted to take into account the complexities of CAPs, academics may resist engaging in this work.

HISTORY OF SOCIAL WORK IN THE CONTEXT OF COLLABORATIVE PARTNERSHIPS

When assessing social work's ability to develop and sustain CAPs and improve the science of collaborative partnerships, it is essential to take into account the field's unique and complex history. Indeed, many of the characteristics that make the field distinctive, and at times have almost pulled the field apart (such as its interdisciplinary lens and boundary-spanning capabilities), are the exact characteristics that make social work the ideal field to enhance the science of collaborative partnerships and give social workers the necessary skills to develop and sustain successful CAPs.

As evidenced by two of the founding mothers of social work, Jane Addams and Mary Richmond, social work has been invested in advocating for disenfranchised, marginalized, and oppressed populations from the inception of the profession (Dulmus, Bass, & Bunch, 2008). The *Code of Ethics of the National Association of Social Workers* (NASW, 2017) supports the advancement of social justice and stresses social workers' responsibility to the broader society to advocate and work for people's general welfare. The NASW *Code of Ethics* also explicitly values "the importance of human relationships" and encourages social workers to engage people as partners in the helping process (NASW, 2017). CAPs give a voice to marginalized individuals by inviting them to participate in the research process; this accomplishes NASW's goals not only by making research findings more translatable and relevant, but also by helping to strengthen relationships between communities and academics and increasing the trust between universities and communities.

Throughout the history of the field, social workers have been liaisons among social groups and institutions. Social workers, at the intersection of many disciplines and organizations, have been categorized as "boundary spanners," that is, "professionals who bridge borders, and in doing so transform relationships" (Stuart, 2007, p. 13). Social workers have also been known as "mediators" who mobilize other professions when needed (for example, doctors) for their clients, and social work has been criticized as not being a true profession because of this role (Flexner, 1915). The opposition to Flexner's assertion was strong—Mary Richmond (1917) posited that social workers'

focus on individual relationships and adjustment of those relationships was a demanding task that other professions were not suited to complete. Furthermore, Jane Addams (1930) explained that social workers have the distinct advantage of being outsiders to other professions—making it easier for them to identify needs or solutions due to the diversity of experiences of social workers. It is clear from Richmond's and Addams's arguments that social workers as mediators were and still are necessary in response to increasingly complex organizations and changing social relationships. Indeed, the ability to navigate complex relationships and identify needs or solutions are necessary skills in the development and sustainment of CAPs.

Given the unique role that social workers have played throughout the history of the field as boundary spanners (or mediators) between individuals, organizations, and institutions (for example, universities), it is clear that social workers have been acting as partnership developers and sustainers in one way or another for decades. The specific skills that social workers have related to boundary spanning, such as relationship building, understanding complex relationships and organizations, coordinating the two, and advocating for the client are all assets to CAP development and sustainment. Thanks to social work's unique history and training, social workers inherently know and use these skills every day—whereas other fields who attempt to develop or sustain CAPs may have to develop these skills from scratch. This places social work at an advantage when considering the development and sustainment of collaborative partnerships between researchers at academic institutions and communities.

From its inception, social work has been committed to collaborative partnership between the practitioner and the client. Bertha Reynolds (1951) suggested that collaboration between practitioner and client resembles an alliance that entails ongoing availability, reciprocity, and receptivity to perceptions and feedback (Simon, 1994). For Reynolds, an alliance hinges on three things:

A shared sense of urgency concerning the problems confronting the client, a conjoint commitment to problem solving in as democratic manner as possible, and a shared emphasis, initiated by the worker, on the common humanity of both members of the relationship, despite what may be marked by

distinctions in social class, race, life chances, and education. (Simon, 1994, p. 8)

CAPs are a scale-up of the collaboration between client and practitioner—the three alliance-building strategies Reynolds outlined are equally translatable when building and sustaining collaborative partnerships, given that equitable relationships are essential in CAPs (Drahota et al., 2016). Social work practitioners and academicians are already experts at alliance building with clients; these skills may be naturally extended to build alliances between communities and academic institutions. In doing so, social work researchers stand to improve relationships between academics and community members and, in turn, work to improve the relevancy and feasibility of research findings in community settings (Kobeissi et al., 2011).

Finally, social workers have always been concerned about issues of power, privilege, social class, and race and ethnicity. Multiple models (for example, anti-oppressive social work, critical social work) have been developed by social workers who work to create an egalitarian environment that is free from oppression and discrimination both within individual practice and on a more macro level by encouraging engagement in the political and legal fields (Strier, 2007). Given the development of these models and the skills that social workers learn along with them, it is likely that the field is well poised to address issues that may arise in collaborative partnerships around power, social class, race and ethnicity, and privilege (Chavez et al., 2008).

FUTURE DIRECTIONS FOR COLLABORATIVE PARTNERSHIPS IN SOCIAL WORK

Given that leading scholars have identified partnership between research and community stakeholders as a key mechanism to bridging the research-to-practice gap to improve health outcomes for marginalized individuals, CAPs and the science of collaborative partnerships have become increasingly important for the helping professions (Chambers & Azrin, 2013; Viswanathan et al., 2004). Social work's history of advocating for marginalized individuals, acting as a boundary spanner between organizations and professions, and addressing issues around power and privilege all place the field in a unique position to have a great impact on CAPs and the science of collaborative partnerships. Furthermore, social work academics play a unique role in

academia in that they are encouraged to conduct practice research (Galinsky et al., 1993) and are invested in opposing the roots and outcomes of social oppression (Strier, 2007). The field's unique history and role in academia place social work researchers in a distinctive position to establish and sustain CAPs as well as further develop and strengthen the science of collaborative partnerships.

The science of collaborative partnerships can only be advanced if there is a common set of terminologies, versus the large variety of names collaborative partnerships have been given in the past. Given that CAPs span a variety of disciplines, it is important to establish a standardized terminology and conceptual definition for collaborative partnerships (Drahota et al., 2016). Based on a systematic review of the literature, and an iterative process from the findings, Drahota and colleagues (2016) have established CAPs as the standardized conceptual definition for collaborative partnerships. The field of social work can take steps toward advancing the science of collaborative partnerships by adopting this conceptual definition to assist with the process of the standardization of terminology.

In addition, collaboration researchers are encouraged to standardize the reporting of CAPs as an important step in creating consistent methodology. Social work researchers studying and engaging in collaborations should include the following characteristics of CAPs in their reporting: information on funding source and process of obtaining funding for the CAP, initiation of partnership, number of partners, composition (that is, position type) of members at beginning and throughout the CAP, retention of CAP members, and CAP duration (Drahota et al., 2016).

In addition to standardizing reporting of characteristics in evaluations of CAPs, social work researchers studying and engaging in collaborations should consider incorporating theory-based models to guide the development, sustainment, and evaluation of CAPs, such as the model of research–community partnership (Brookman-Frazee, Stahmer, Lewis, Feder, & Reed, 2012). Theory-based models assist with identifying specific facilitating or hindering factors in the collaborative process. Identifying these may improve future collaborations and enhance the field's understanding of the best ways to carry out partnerships while maximizing facilitators and minimizing hindrances in specific contexts, so as to tailor collaborations in the future.

Beyond using standardized terminology, methodology, and evaluation, social work researchers studying collaboration should also work to increase their ability to develop and sustain CAPs within their own institutions. Researchers attempting to engage in CAPs often face barriers inside the university in which they are employed (Nyden, 2003). Although this may be less true for social work, given the interdisciplinary nature of the field and the encouragement to conduct practice research from within the field (Galinsky et al., 1993), this issue has not been systematically studied. Considering that CAPs are time-intensive affairs and have the potential to affect a scholar's productivity rate, it may be wise for social work academics to get buy-in from their academic institution to participate in this work. Scholars may be wise to have a second stream of research that they can pursue (and publish on) while they are engaging in community-partnered research. Whereas CAPs do require a significant time commitment up front, a sustained CAP can make it much easier to conduct research over the long run—a rationale that should further incentivize academic institutions to support CAPs.

Social work programs that wish to institutionalize CAPs can dedicate resources internally to academics who wish to engage in this type of work. One specific resource that social work programs could provide is a centralized university–community research center that is run by social workers (practitioners, academics, or both) who organize and advocate for researchers and community stakeholders who wish to engage in collaborative partnerships. University–community research centers are meant to be interdisciplinary, pulling together faculty and students who are interested and involved in CAPs from multiple disciplines to create a single voice. In doing so, the center becomes an institutional advocate for researchers engaged in CAPs and gives them better bargaining power with colleagues and the larger university (Nyden, 2003). Furthermore, the center could become an accessible port of entry for community stakeholders who wish to work with the university but may not know where to begin. Center staff could act as “matchmakers” between these community partners and faculty or graduate students who have similar goals and assist with developing relationships. In addition, a center of this sort could act as a place of support for researchers across the university engaging in

collaborative partnerships—a place for researchers to network, receive technical and practice-based assistance, and brainstorm and conceptualize CAPs (Nyden, 2003).

Having expertise in navigating complex relationships, traversing power dynamics, and advocating for marginalized individuals (who are often the individuals researchers are engaging with when conducting community-based research), social workers are at an advantage in managing and staffing a center of this sort. In return for this investment of resources, researchers and universities not only improve the validity of their research, but also work to mend gaps in trust between academic institutions and community members by ensuring that research is relevant to the community and that it empowers people who historically have had little say in the research performed on or about them (Baker, Homan, Schonhoff, & Kreuter, 1999; Palinkas et al., 2017).

Universities should increase incentives for academics to use collaborative partnerships in their work. Due to the unique history of the field, social work programs are well poised to set an example of incentive structures that encourage community-partnered research. In tenure and promotion guidelines, social work programs can formally recognize community impact as one of the ways in which an academic work can be judged (Nyden, 2003). An emphasis on community outreach in a concrete way should be added to evaluations for academics—encouraging academics to translate their research to tools for the community, policy briefs, lectures, and trainings with community members on the findings. Use of evaluative statements from community partners could also be incorporated into academics' promotion reviews. Adding recognition of the community impact, outreach, and relationship building an academic is engaging in tenure, and promotion guidelines, rewards community-engaged research and may increase the use of CAPs (Nyden, 2003). Upon adopting these guidelines, social work programs have the opportunity to set an example for the larger university in which they are housed of a discipline that truly values and incentivizes community-partnered research.

Finally, if social work programs wish to truly build a culture where engaging in community-partnered research is valued and used, integrating education and instruction on how to engage in and evaluate CAPs in doctoral training and continuing education is

essential. CAPs require a nuanced take on identifying research questions, specifying research designs and methods, and engaging with communities that may not ordinarily be taught in a doctoral curriculum. For example, community-engaged research likely requires specific competencies that researchers should attain before conducting community-partnered research (Shea et al., 2017; Pellecchia et al., 2018). To ensure the success of CAPs and advancement of the science of collaborative partnerships, social work programs should consider developing coursework or workshops around these competencies, partnership strategies, and methods to evaluate CAPs. In doing so, they enhance their students' readiness to participate in CAPs and increase the likelihood that community-partnered research will become a norm in the field.

CONCLUSION

Given that leading scholars have identified partnership between research and community stakeholders as a key mechanism through which to bridge the research-to-practice gap, and funding agencies have recently emphasized the centrality of research-practice partnerships (Chambers & Azrin, 2013), it is clear that science of collaborative research is only going to become more important in academia as time progresses. Social work researchers should capitalize on the unique skills that have historically defined them (for example, boundary spanners, experts in developing alliances and navigating complex relationships) to enhance their ability to be at the forefront of the collaborative partnership movement in academia. **SW**

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POINTS & VIEWPOINTS

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